

CHARLESE SABALLE

USER RESEARCH LEAD

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PROFILE

User research leader with 6+ years turning player and consumer insight into product, brand, and portfolio decisions, on top of 10+ years in analytics and operations across global teams. I uncover how people engage with the things they use and play, and translate those insights into decisions that shape product, content, and strategy.

I currently lead player research for Merge Mansion at Metacore, where I built the function from ground up and partner with cross-functional teams across the game lifecycle, from early concept and live-ops to brand strategy and long-term direction.

I combine quantitative rigor with qualitative depth, and I work comfortably in ambiguity, forming clear points of view that help teams move with confidence. I also line-manage and develop researchers, and act as AI champion for the research craft.

WORK EXPERIENCE

UX & Player Research Lead *(Acting initially, formal promotion April 2026)*

Nov 2025 - present

Senior UX & Player Researcher

Oct 2023 - Nov 2025

Metacore Games Oy (Helsinki)

Lead player research for Merge Mansion (€600M+ lifetime revenue, 60M+ downloads). Partner with design, product, brand, analytics, and leadership across the full game lifecycle.

- **Built the player research function from zero:** player portraits and personas, satisfaction tracking, research intake, research roadmap, insights repository, and vendor and panel processes. Grew the team from 1 to 2.
- **Brand strategy:** Led the Brand Health study that surfaced the high-awareness / low-conversion gap and named under-leveraged brand assets (Grandma, premium tone, family mystery). Findings became the foundation for a full brand refresh, re-anchoring around the Mansion and Grandma, simplifying the cast, and evolving key brand elements. Now positioned by leadership as central to Merge Mansion's long-term growth.
- **Game modernisation (company top priority):** Player research recommendations on character style ("realistic but polished with mild stylisation") and visual energy ("warm vibrancy") accepted by the team; now informing the modernisation direction across the game.
- **Economy and retention:** Area Satisfaction and Churn research drove rebalancing across 8 in-game areas, reducing friction, restoring flow, and making it easier for lapsed players to return. Milestone area: area churn -22%, area satisfaction up from 3.41 to 3.57, ARPPU +5%.
- **Feature development:** Research informed the Display Task on Board redesign, a major UI shift bringing tasks onto the main board for the first time. Results: d7 retention +6% (new players); merge goals completed +2.8% (existing) and +6% (new players).
- **Evidence-based decision-making:** Player research alongside the late-areas A/B test surfaced the gap between perceived difficulty improvements and actual satisfaction, informing the team's decision to revert and reframing late-game satisfaction not driven by difficulty.
- **Team development:** Manage one direct report (mentorship to indirect to direct management). Coached statistical methods (t-tests, chi-square, Mann-Whitney, MaxDiff) and shifted their working mode from research-as-service to embedded development partner.
- **AI in research practice:** Built a Notion-based insights repository optimised for Notion AI retrieval using the Atomic Research framework, letting cross-functional teammates query past research and self-serve answers.
- **Operations and tooling:** Run ~2 studies per month; proposed and onboarded new survey tooling unlocking MaxDiff and Conjoint analyses; coach designers in research techniques, scaling craft capability across the studio.
- **Strategic partnership:** Research partner to senior leadership and cross-functional teams; synthesise complex findings into clear narratives that drive feature prioritisation, event tuning, brand decisions, and content direction.

Senior Quantitative User Researcher

Jul 2021 - Sep 2023

Quantitative User Researcher

Aug 2019 - Jul 2021

Zalando SE (Berlin) - Zalando Finland Oy (Helsinki)

Led large-scale consumer research across multiple product verticals, markets, and user segments, generating insights to inform product and portfolio strategy.

- Designed and led end-to-end quantitative and mixed-method research (beta testing, segmentation, experience evaluation), guiding product decisions and launches across multiple teams.
 - Led concept testing for the Zalando Assistant, an AI-powered conversational commerce experience novel to the category at launch. Combined Wizard-of-Oz prototyping, moderated qualitative testing, and quantitative beta testing to identify the four core use cases, surface usability and output-relevance issues, and inform direction on onboarding, tone, and humanisation of the assistant.
 - Advised on go/no-go decisions for major product initiatives; defined the Beauty customer segments that became the foundation for category-level strategy.
 - Built and scaled a multi-market research panel (12,000+ participants across 9 countries) and an accessibility panel; optimised recruitment, cutting cost by 69% and lifting project capacity from 20 to 30 annually.
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SELECTED IMPACT

- **AI in research:** Concept testing shaped the launch direction for the Zalando Assistant in 2023; at Metacore, an Atomic-Research-based insights repository now lets cross-functional teammates self-serve querying past research, freeing capacity for higher-order work.
 - **Sustainability:** Led a brand-partner and industry survey on sustainability communication at Zalando, informing emerging category standards.
 - **DE&I:** Member of Metacore's DE&I committee; drafted the inclusive design lens for game development, a practical framework for building DE&I into the player experience. At Zalando, drove inclusion-focused research that contributed to onboarding 70+ Black-owned brands; co-founded the Asia-Pacific ERG and helped establish an accessibility research panel.
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CORE COMPETENCIES

- **Quantitative Research:** Surveys, MaxDiff, Conjoint, segmentation and clustering, classification modelling, statistical analysis, beta testing.
 - **Qualitative & Mixed-Method:** Playtesting, interviews, usability and concept testing, heuristic evaluation, personas, data triangulation.
 - **Strategy & Research Operations:** Competitor and market analysis, brand health tracking, insights repositories, panel and vendor management, research roadmap and resourcing.
 - **Leadership & Collaboration:** Line management, mentoring, career development, stakeholder management at senior leadership level, workshops, AI-assisted analysis and synthesis.
 - **Tools:** Python, R, SQL, Notion, Qualtrics, Sawtooth, Survey Monkey, Google Workspace, GameRefinery, Sensor Tower, Claude, PlayTestCloud, User Interviews, Asana, Miro, FigJam, Dovetail, Condense.
 - **Domains:** Gaming, e-commerce, consumer tech, DE&I.
 - **Languages:** English (C2), Finnish (B1), Filipino (Native).
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EDUCATION

Big Data Analytics (Specialisation Studies) — Arcada University of Applied Sciences, Helsinki (2021–2022)

Bachelor of Business Administration, Business Information Technology — Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences, Helsinki (2017–2019)

Bachelor of Science in Statistics — University of the Philippines, Quezon City (1999–2004)

TRAININGS AND CERTIFICATIONS

Choice Modeling Master Class: Conjoint Analysis and MaxDiff Methods — Quant UX Association (May 2025)

How to Interpret UX Numbers: Statistics for UX — Nielsen Norman Group (Jan 2021)

SPEAKING ENGAGEMENTS

Anti-racism, and Inclusion and Safety for Trans People — Finnish Games Industry DEI Summit, Helsinki (Dec 2025)

Designing With Ears Open: Listen To Your Players — Pocket Gamer Connects Helsinki (Oct 2025)

Career Pivots and Cultural Shifts: A Migrant's Journey into Tech & Games — Womenize! Berlin (Jun 2025)

When To Say No: Setting Boundaries At Work — Rise And Play x Starberry x Metacore, Berlin (Apr 2024)

Numbers Behind the Scene: Quantitative Research in Practice — UXHel Helsinki (Sep 2021)

PUBLICATIONS

Machine Learning Models to Predict Students' Study Path Selection — International Journal of Interactive Mobile Technologies (Jan 2022)

Experience Changes the Perception and Feelings: A Case Study on MVR Application in Education — International Conference on Education and New Learning Technologies (Jul 2018)

VOLUNTEER & LEADERSHIP

Member, AI & Digital Rights Working Group, European Network Against Racism (2025-present)

Secretary, Anti-Racist Forum (2025–present)

Member & Mentor, We in Games Finland (2024-present)

Member, International Game Developers Association Finland (2023-present)

Course Assistant, UX and Prototyping of Digital Services, Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences (2018-2019)

Executive Board Member, ILGA World (2016-2019)
